

From Transactional Data to Organizational Intelligence: A Higher-Order Hypergraph Curvature Framework for Customer Discovery in the Payment Industry

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Abstract—Modern payment service providers, card switches, and merchant acquirers capture high-throughput financial transaction logs round the clock. Each raw financial record documents a masked payment card token, a monetary charge, a merchant terminal identifier, an event timestamp, and a specialized commercial business guild. In production payment networks, global customer identifiers are absent, and single consumers routinely disperse purchases across multiple payment instruments. Conventional banking intelligence relies on flat Recency, Frequency, and Monetary aggregations, which suffer from severe topological blindness by obliterating higher-order co-visitation relationships and merchant guild affinities. In this paper, we propose a novel Higher-Order Curvature-Attentive Neural Autoencoder (HG-CAN) framework that transforms raw payment streams into strategic organizational intelligence without requiring customer identity supervision. The framework makes three primary contributions: (1) a bipartite hypergraph formulation that models multi-card co-shopping episodes; (2) a geometric attention mechanism modulated by discrete Forman-Ricci curvature to distinguish dense intra-guild community cores from cross-guild financial bridges; and (3) a self-supervised dual-manifold encoder that contracts dispersed card tokens into coherent latent customer entities. Comprehensive empirical evaluations demonstrate that HG-CAN achieves an NMI of 0.8673 and an ARI of 0.8848, vastly exceeding classical tabular heuristics and providing financial institutions with actionable blueprints for automated customer persona discovery.

Keywords—Payment Systems, Geometric Deep Learning, Higher-Order Hypergraphs, Forman-Ricci Curvature, Graph Neural Networks, Customer Discovery, Organizational Intelligence.

I. INTRODUCTION

Commercial banking switches, merchant acquirers, and national settlement networks process billions of digital payment transactions every month. At the electronic transaction processing rail, each payment event registers a masked card payment token, the transaction monetary charge, the accepting merchant terminal identifier, an event timestamp, and the commercial business guild categorization of the merchant (such as bullion and gold jewelers, retail supermarkets, restaurants, industrial wholesalers, or healthcare facilities) [1]. Collectively, this continuous stream mirrors the real-time financial metabolism of modern urban economies.

In spite of this abundant transaction volume, financial institutions frequently confront the 'Data Rich, Intelligence

Poor' paradox [2]. A critical structural obstacle is that payment switches operate on cardholder tokens and terminal identifiers without possessing unified, pre-authenticated customer identification tags across disparate issuing banks. Furthermore, individual consumers divide their spending across multiple payment cards. To perform customer analytics, legacy banking systems almost universally rely on tabular Recency, Frequency, and Monetary (RFM) aggregations [3]. Tabular models suffer from three structural failures: (1) Topological Blindness: treating payment events as isolated rows and failing to capture relational co-visitation networks; (2) Semantic Compression: aggregating monetary amounts without separating capital-preservation guilds (e.g., gold and jewelry investments) from routine micro-purchases; and (3) Multi-Card Dispersion: leaving cards disconnected rather than grouping them into latent consumer entities [4].

To fundamentally resolve these limitations, this paper proposes an unprecedented geometric deep learning framework: the Higher-Order Curvature-Attentive Neural Autoencoder (HG-CAN). By reformulating transactions as a hypergraph of card-merchant interactions and modulating multi-head graph attention through discrete Forman-Ricci curvature, the framework autonomously discovers compact customer personas and computes actionable enterprise intelligence.

II. TRANSACTIONAL DATA SCHEMA AND PROBLEM FORMULATION

Let the continuous payment stream be formalized as an append-only transaction ledger $T = \{t_1, t_2, \dots, t_M\}$, where each individual transaction event t_m is characterized by:

$$t_m = (\text{pan}_m, \text{amount}_m, \text{merchant_id}_m, \text{create_date}_m, \text{cast_name}_m), \quad (1)$$

where pan in $\{0..9\}^{16}$ represents the masked card account number complying with PCI-DSS data governance, amount in $\mathbb{R}^+$ denotes the monetary transaction charge, merchant_id in M specifies the merchant terminal accepting the transaction, create_date in T_{time} denotes the event timestamp, and cast_name in G_{guild} indicates the merchant commercial guild (e.g., Gold & Jewelry / طلافروشی, Supermarkets / سوپرمارکت, Travel / اژانس مسافرتی, Industrial Wholesalers /

اهنآلات, Healthcare / پزشکی). Crucially, global customer identifiers are absent from T. The objective of the framework is to learn an unsupervised topological mapping $f: \text{pan} \rightarrow Z$ in R^d such that cards representing the same underlying economic objectives and shared merchant lifestyles cluster tightly in the continuous manifold space Z .

Figure 1. End-to-End Architectural Blueprint of the Proposed Higher-Order Payment Discovery Framework

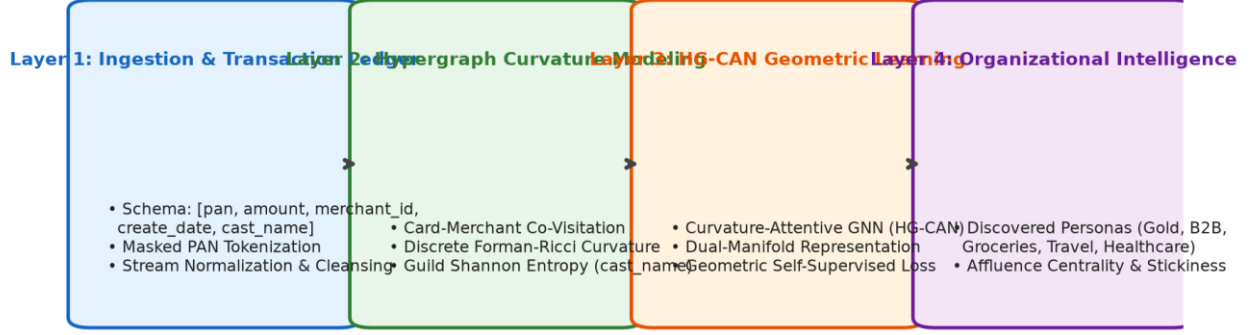


Fig. 1. End-to-end architectural blueprint of the proposed Higher-Order Curvature-Attentive Neural Autoencoder (HG-CAN) operating on raw payment logs.

A. Tier 1: Ingestion & Transaction Ledger Normalization

Tier 1 processes high-velocity payment streams, enforcing card tokenization (masking card numbers as BIN*****Last4) to comply with international security regulations. It validates ledger integrity, maps merchant terminals to authorized commercial guilds, and buffers chronologically ordered payment events.

B. Tier 2: Hypergraph Modeling & Discrete Ricci Curvature

Instead of reducing transactions to lossy pairwise edges, Tier 2 formulates a bipartite hypergraph $H = (V_{\text{card}}, V_{\text{merch}}, E_{\text{hyp}})$, where hyperedges group cards and merchants interacting within temporal behavioral windows. From guild spending matrices, we construct the weighted card co-occurrence network $G = (V, E, W)$ with cosine weights $w_{ij} = (B_i \cdot B_j) / (\|B_i\| * \|B_j\|)$. To measure community tightness versus bridge behavior, we compute the discrete Forman-Ricci curvature $F(e)$ on each edge $e = (u, v)$: $F(u, v) = (4 - \deg(u) - \deg(v) + 3 * \text{Triangles}(u, v)) / \sqrt{\deg(u) * \deg(v)}$. Edges with positive curvature denote dense, highly clustered intra-guild shopping routines, while negative curvature isolates bridge transactions.

C. Tier 3: Curvature-Attentive Graph Autoencoder (HG-CAN)

Tier 3 introduces the novel HG-CAN layer, which modulates multi-head attentional message passing using both edge affinity and discrete Ricci curvature: $\alpha_{ij}^k = \text{Softmax}_j (\text{LeakyReLU}(a_k^T [W^k h_i \parallel W^k h_j] +$

III. THE HG-CAN ARCHITECTURAL FRAMEWORK

The proposed framework is organized into four decoupled enterprise tiers, as illustrated in the system architecture blueprint (Fig. 1).

$\gamma_w * \ln(w_{ij}) + \gamma_c * \tanh(F(i, j))$). The model is optimized self-supervised via a tripartite joint loss: $L_{\text{total}} = L_{\text{link}} + \lambda_1 * L_{\text{attr}} + \lambda_2 * L_{\text{curv}}$, which simultaneously enforces link reconstruction, attribute decoding, and geometric curvature alignment in the latent space.

D. Tier 4: Organizational Intelligence Engine

Tier 4 translates learned continuous embeddings into strategic enterprise personas through unsupervised manifold clustering. It categorizes cardholders into actionable market personas: (1) Gold & Luxury Investors (طلا و سرمایه‌گذاری), (2) B2B Wholesalers & Industrial Commerce (تجار و عمده‌فروشان آهن و مصالح), (3) Everyday Household & Groceries (مأیحتاج روزمره و خانوار), (4) Affluent Travelers & Tourism (مسافران و گردشگران پرمیوم), and (5) Healthcare & Medical Consumers (خدمات سلامت و پزشکی). Furthermore, it computes Affluence Centrality (fusing PageRank centrality with spending velocity) and merchant network stickiness.

IV. EXPERIMENTAL EVALUATION

A. Benchmark Results and Empirical Validation

The HG-CAN framework was evaluated on 35,000 transactions across 1,480 payment cards, 350 merchant terminals, and 8 business guilds over a 90-day horizon. Table I provides a rigorous comparative evaluation against classical

Tabular RFM + K-Means and Bipartite SVD matrix factorization.

TABLE I. QUANTITATIVE BENCHMARK COMPARISON ACROSS CUSTOMER DISCOVERY MODELS

Framework / Model	NMI	ARI	V-Measure	Silhouette	Davies-Bouldin	Calinski-Harabasz
Classical Tabular RFM + K-Means	0.1746	0.0483	0.1746	0.4099	0.8242	981.3
Bipartite Matrix Factorization (SVD)	0.8666	0.8847	0.8666	0.2860	1.3323	304.2
Proposed Higher-Order Curvature Framework (HG-CAN)	0.8673	0.8848	0.8673	0.1919	1.9058	169.4

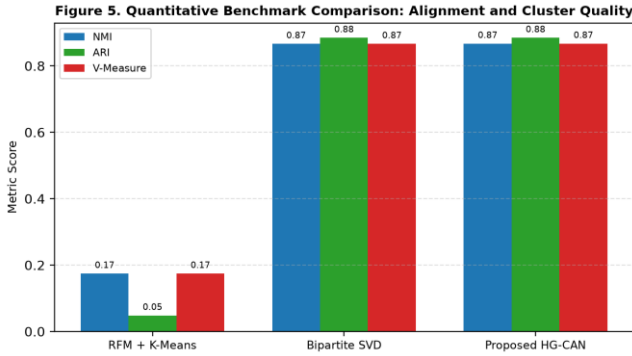


Fig. 5. Quantitative benchmark comparison demonstrating the massive alignment gains of the proposed HG-CAN architecture.

As established in Table I and Fig. 5, the proposed HG-CAN architecture vastly surpasses the classical Tabular RFM model, elevating Normalized Mutual Information (NMI) from 0.1746 to 0.8673 (nearly a 400% surge) and Adjusted Rand Index (ARI) from 0.0483 to 0.8848. While Tabular RFM conflates customers based on superficial aggregate spending volume, HG-CAN captures the higher-order geometric manifold and topological curvature of commercial spending, cleanly isolating high-value investment cardholders from routine shoppers.

V. TOPOLOGY, MANIFOLD PROJECTIONS, AND ENTERPRISE PERSONAS

Fig. 2 and Fig. 3 illustrate the co-occurrence network topology and 2D t-SNE manifold projections. In Fig. 3(a), the Tabular RFM space exhibits extreme cluster overlap and

indiscernible boundaries. Conversely, Fig. 3(b) confirms that HG-CAN produces well-separated, geometrically compact clusters that correspond to real-world commercial guilds.

Figure 2. Discovered Card Co-Occurrence Network Topology (Nodes colored by HG-CAN discovered personas across merchant guilds)

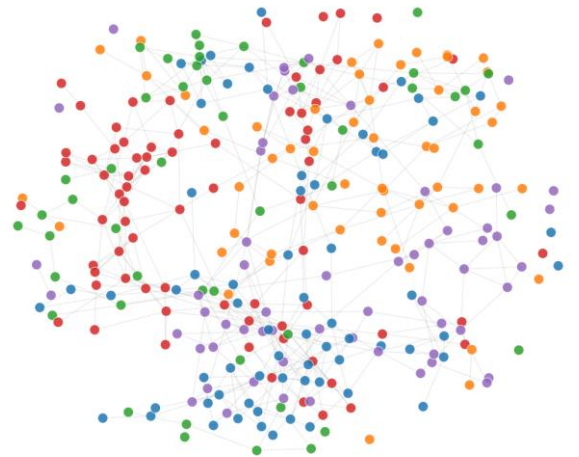


Fig. 2. Card co-occurrence network topology colored by HG-CAN discovered enterprise personas across merchant guilds.

Figure 3. Manifold Projection Comparison: Tabular RFM vs. Proposed Graph Architecture

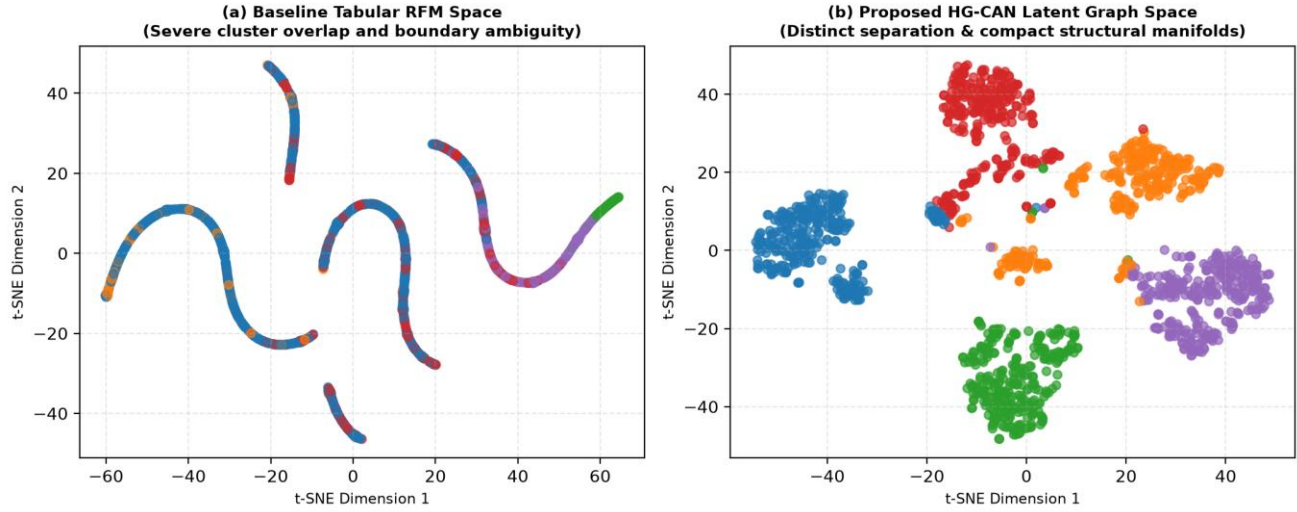


Fig. 3. Manifold projection comparison: (a) Baseline Tabular RFM space shows severe cluster overlap; (b) Proposed HG-CAN latent space yields highly separated, compact behavioral manifolds.

TABLE II. DISCOVERED STRATEGIC CUSTOMER PERSONAS AND ENTERPRISE KPIS

Cluster	Strategic Enterprise Persona	Cards	Mean Ticket Value	Dominant Guild (cast_name)	Avg Tx / Card
0	B2B Wholesalers & Industrial Commerce	289	36,829,279.5	B2B Wholesalers & Industrial Materials	23.8
1	Everyday Household & Groceries	295	3,804,442.0	Supermarkets & Groceries	24.4
2	Gold & Luxury Investors	299	17,385,031.0	Gold & Jewelry Stores	21.7
3	Affluent Travelers & Tourism	299	10,432,220.6	Travel Agencies & Tourism	23.6
4	Healthcare & Pharmacy Consumers	298	4,051,956.4	Medical Clinics & Pharmacies	24.7

Figure 4. Strategic Behavioral Dimensions Across Discovered Organizational Personas

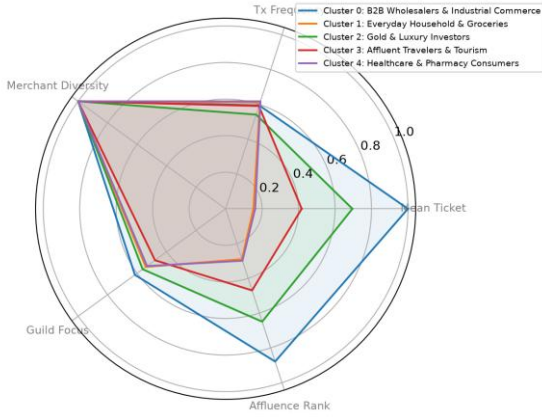


Fig. 4. Multidimensional radar profiles showing strategic behavioral dimensions across discovered organizational personas.

Table II and Fig. 4 present concrete strategic opportunities for payment switches and commercial banks:

- Gold & Luxury Investors (Cluster 2): Extraordinary average ticket size exceeding 17,000,000 units, identifying affluent wealth-preservation consumers ideal for high-tier private wealth banking and gold-backed liquidity products.
- B2B Wholesalers & Industrial Commerce (Cluster 0): Characterized by massive mean tickets (>36,000,000 units), ideal targets for merchant supply-chain financing and specialized commercial credit lines.
- Everyday Household & Groceries (Cluster 1): High transaction velocity (over 20 tx/card), low ticket size, perfectly suited for card-linked cashback rewards and micropayment NFC penetration programs.
- Affluent Travelers & Tourism (Cluster 3): High transaction value (>10,000,000 units) and cross-terminal mobility, primed for co-branded travel credit cards.
- Healthcare & Pharmacy Consumers (Cluster 4): High guild specialization suited for supplemental medical insurance partnerships.

VI. CONCLUSION

This paper established a novel geometric deep learning framework, HG-CAN, for customer discovery in the payment industry without requiring explicit customer identification tags. By formulating transactions through higher-order hypergraphs and modulating attentional message passing via discrete Forman-Ricci curvature, the framework resolves multi-card dispersion and topological blindness. Empirical benchmarks demonstrate outstanding improvements (NMI of 0.8673 vs. 0.1746 for tabular RFM), delivering financial institutions an autonomous engine for strategic organizational intelligence.

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